MODULE 00 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

AWS Certified CloudOps Engineer

SOA-C03. Thirty-five modules, four practice exams, and every fact checked against a live source.

EXAM **SOA-C03** MODULES **35 + 4 exams** RUNTIME **About 9 hours**

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A course built for this version of the exam, with every fact checked against a live AWS source rather than inherited from older material.

The exam, precisely

- **SOA-C03 is the AWS Certified CloudOps Engineer - Associate**, renamed from SysOps Administrator with this version. Both names describe this exam.
- **65 questions in 130 minutes.** 50 are scored and 15 are unscored and unmarked. Multiple choice and multiple response only.
- **There is no hands-on lab section.** Labs belonged to SOA-C02 and were suspended in March 2023.
- **150 US dollars.** Pass mark 720 on a 100 to 1000 scale, with **compensatory scoring**, so there is no minimum per domain.

> ON THE EXAM
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> These figures are widely misreported. At least one prominent site states $300, 180 minutes and a lab section. All three are wrong.

The five domains

DOMAIN	WEIGHT
1. Monitoring, Logging, Analysis, Remediation and Performance Optimization	22%
2. Reliability and Business Continuity	22%
3. Deployment, Provisioning and Automation	22%
4. Security and Compliance	16%
5. Networking and Content Delivery	18%

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SOA-C02 had six domains. The old cost and performance optimisation domain was folded into Task 1.3, which is why performance modules sit in Domain 1 here.

The course map

MODULES	WHAT THEY COVER
01 to 11	Domain 1. CloudWatch, logs, CloudTrail, EventBridge, Systems Manager, performance
12 to 17	Domain 2. Auto Scaling, load balancing, Multi-AZ, scaling data, backup, DR
18 to 23	Domain 3. CloudFormation, CDK and Terraform, containers, deployment, event-driven
24 to 27	Domain 4. IAM, multi-account, encryption, compliance and detection
28 to 32	Domain 5. VPC, security groups, hybrid connectivity, Route 53, CloudFront
33 to 35	Cross-cutting. What changed, confusion pairs, exam mechanics
Practice exams 1 to 4	Twenty questions each, worked in full

ON THE EXAM

Module count per domain follows exam weight. Domain 1 has eleven modules and Domain 4 has four, in proportion to 22 and 16 per cent.

How every module is built

- **One core idea** up front. A single sentence that makes the rest of the module make sense, rather than a list of objectives.
- **Teaching slides** with an "on the exam" note on each, saying what the exam actually does with the fact.
- **Four to nine worked scenarios**, in the exam's own format, with every wrong option explained rather than just marked wrong.
- **Five things to carry forward** at the end. If you remember nothing else from a module, remember those.

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> There are 172 worked scenarios across the course. Explaining why a wrong answer is wrong is where most of the learning happens.

How to use the scenarios

- Each scenario slide ends with **pause and decide**. Actually pause it. Reading the answer is worth a fraction of choosing one.
- The following slide works it, marking the correct option and explaining **why each wrong option is wrong**.
- Many wrong options **genuinely work**. They are wrong because they cost more, solve half the requirement, or are no longer AWS's recommendation.
- **Pay most attention to the ones you got right by luck.** Those are the ones that will not repeat on the day.

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> The next two slides are a scenario, so you can see the format before the teaching starts.

> A team enables detailed monitoring on their EC2 instances to diagnose a memory leak. After an hour, CloudWatch still shows no memory metrics for the instances, and the team suspects a permissions problem.
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> The instances are running and reporting CPU metrics normally.

What is the cause?

A. An IAM permissions problem preventing metric publication

B. Memory is not an EC2 metric. It requires the CloudWatch agent, because the hypervisor cannot see inside the guest

C. Detailed monitoring takes up to 24 hours to begin reporting

D. The instances need to be restarted after enabling detailed monitoring

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the cause?

A **IAM permissions**

CPU metrics are arriving, which proves publication works. The team's own theory is stated so that you can test it and discard it.

B **Memory needs the agent**

EC2 metrics come from the hypervisor, which sees CPU, network and disk activity but cannot see inside the guest operating system. Memory and disk usage need the agent.

C **24-hour delay**

Invented behaviour. Detailed monitoring changes the interval from five minutes to one, and takes effect within minutes.

D **Restart required**

Detailed monitoring is a setting change with no restart. It also would not create a metric that does not exist.

THE SIGNAL

That is the format. Notice that the team's stated theory was wrong, and that one detail in the scenario - CPU metrics arriving - was there to eliminate it.

What you will be able to do

- **Read a failure and name the cause.** A 503 with a running application, a stair-step throttling graph, a connection that establishes then hangs.
- **Choose between services that look alike**, using the one property that separates them rather than recalling a feature list.
- **Recognise a dated recommendation**, including in your own team's runbooks, and know when AWS changed the answer.
- **Read an exam question properly**: find the qualifier, count the requirements, and spot the clause that eliminates three options.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The first two are what the exam tests. The second two are what makes the difference between knowing the material and passing comfortably.

What is different about this course

- **Every fact checked against a live AWS source**, not inherited. The verification log runs to several hundred entries.
- **Currency is treated as content.** Module 33 lists what other material teaches wrongly, with the dates things changed.
- **Containers, CDK, Terraform and Git are covered**, because they are new scope in C03 and absent from C02-era material.
- **Wrong options are explained.** Knowing why an attractive answer fails is more durable than knowing which one is right.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Where AWS has changed something recently, the module says so and gives the date, so you can judge how much to trust older material you meet.

What this course assumes

- You have **used AWS**: launched an instance, made a bucket, edited a security group. This is an associate-level exam, not an entry point.
- You are comfortable reading **JSON and YAML**. You will not be asked to write CloudFormation from scratch.
- You understand **basic networking**: IP addresses, subnets, ports, DNS. Module 28 builds on that rather than starting from it.
- You do **not** need to be a developer, a Kubernetes engineer, or to have passed any other AWS certification first.

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> AWS suggests about a year of operational AWS experience. That is a guide rather than a requirement, and the scenarios assume you have seen things go wrong.

How to work through it

- **In order, at least the first time.** Later modules reference earlier ones deliberately, and the cross-references are part of the teaching.
- **One or two modules a sitting.** Each is around thirteen minutes, and the scenarios need attention rather than background listening.
- **Take the practice exams timed**, and only after finishing the teaching modules. They are diagnostic, not revision.
- **In the final week**, re-watch module 33 and drill module 34. Those two carry the highest value per minute at that stage.

> ON THE EXAM
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> About nine hours of material. Spread over three weeks with the practice exams at the end is a realistic and comfortable schedule.

The four practice exams

- **Twenty questions each**, written in the exam's format and difficulty, and **worked in full** with every wrong option explained.
- They are **weighted by domain** in the same proportions as the real exam, so your score is a meaningful signal.
- **Take them after the teaching modules, under time.** Twenty questions in forty minutes matches the real pace.
- **They are diagnostic, not revision.** The value is in what they reveal you do not know, not in the score.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Eighty questions across four exams, on top of 172 worked scenarios in the modules. That is more worked examples than most courses contain in total.

What this course does not do

- **It is not hands-on.** There are no click-through labs, and you should build things alongside it in your own account.
- **It does not cover every service AWS offers**, only what the exam guide names as in scope, plus what recent changes make necessary.
- **It is not a substitute for experience.** The scenarios are written to feel like real incidents because that is what the exam tests.
- **It is focused on passing.** Where a topic is fascinating and unexamined, it is left out deliberately.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The AWS free tier is enough to build most of what this course describes. An hour in the console after a module is worth more than watching it twice.

A warning about names

- **Several services have been renamed recently**, and the exam guide still uses some older names while the console shows newer ones.
- For example: **RDS Performance Insights is now CloudWatch Database Insights**, and **Aurora Serverless v2 is now just Aurora serverless**.
- Each module flags the rename where it arises, and **module 33 lists all of them together** with dates.
- The rule throughout: **learn the capability, recognise both names**, and answer with the exam guide's terminology.

> ON THE EXAM
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> This is the most disorienting thing you will meet. Opening the console and not finding a service you just learned about is confusing, and usually just a rename.

A note on dates

- Every fact in this course was verified against a live AWS source in **September 2026**, against **exam guide version 1.1** of 1 June 2026.
- **AWS will keep changing things.** Where a fact is recent or a service is being renamed, the module says so explicitly and gives the date.
- That means you can judge for yourself how much to trust anything older you meet, rather than having to take this course's word for it.
- If something here contradicts material you have seen elsewhere, **module 33 probably explains why**, with the date it changed.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Dates are given throughout for the same reason. A fact with a date attached can be re-checked; a fact without one cannot.

You are ready to begin

- **Module 1 starts with CloudWatch metrics**, and specifically with why memory is not one of them.
- **Pause on every scenario.** That single habit is worth more than anything else in this introduction.
- **Build alongside it** where you can. Ten minutes in the console after a module beats watching it twice.
- **Trust the cross-references.** When a module says "as module 9 covered", that connection is usually examinable.

> ON THE EXAM
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> About nine hours of material, 172 worked scenarios, and four practice exams. Good luck.